Write Down What Your Wife Needs Before Anyone Says Assisted Living

Four prompts to turn what you see at home into a plain list of the help your wife needs, sort the essentials from the preferences, and gather the questions her care team should answer before you look at any place.

Where you are

The hospital social worker has started saying “assisted living” and “memory care,” and a decision about your wife is a few weeks away at most. You know what she needs at home, hour by hour. You don't know what those labels actually cover.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can describe the help your wife needs in plain tasks, separate what any arrangement must provide from what you'd simply like, and hand her care team a list of what they need to confirm before you choose.

A one-page list with three headings: Help She Needs Every Day, Must Have Versus Would Like, and Questions for Her Care Team.

Before you start

- Your own account of a day with your wife, from waking to bed.
- Anything written down by a nurse, therapist, or discharge planner.
- The questions you keep meaning to ask someone. You don't need a diagnosis letter to begin.

PROMPT 1

Describe the help in tasks, not labels

WHY THIS MATTERS

“Assisted living” and “memory care” are categories, not descriptions of your wife. What you can describe is who helps her stand up, who reminds her to eat, and when. That's the language a decision should be made in.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on one ordinary day with her, start to finish.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is a day with my wife, from waking to bed, written the way it happens:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Turn it into a table of the help she needs, one row per task. Columns: TASK, KIND OF HELP (hands on, standing by, reminding, or doing it for her), WHEN I'VE SEEN IT NEEDED, and HOW SURE I AM. Fill the third column only from what I've described; if I haven't said when, write NOT OBSERVED. Do not suggest a level of care, a type of facility, or a provider. I'm only trying to describe the help, not where it comes from.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Rows marked NOT OBSERVED. Those are the parts of her day you'll want to watch before anyone asks you about them.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Over the next two days, fill in as many NOT OBSERVED rows as you can from what you see.

PROMPT 2

Sort must-haves from would-likes

WHY THIS MATTERS

Two places with the same sign on the door can offer very different help. You can only tell them apart if you know which of your wife's needs are non-negotiable and which are preferences.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The table from the first prompt and a few notes on what matters to her about how she lives.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the list of help my wife needs, plus some things that matter to her about how she lives:
>
> [PASTE THE TABLE FROM PROMPT 1 AND YOUR NOTES ON HER PREFERENCES]
>
> Sort everything into two columns: MUST HAVE, for help she cannot manage without, and WOULD LIKE, for things that would make life better but aren't essential. Add a third list, NOT SURE WHICH, and put every medical, medication, or supervision item there rather than deciding for me. Under each MUST HAVE, write one sentence on what I'd ask any arrangement to show me so I know they can actually do it.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A MUST HAVE column short enough to remember, and a NOT SURE WHICH list that's longer than you expected.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the MUST HAVE column to your wife if she's able, and to one other family member, and see if they agree.

PROMPT 3

Find the questions only her care team can answer

WHY THIS MATTERS

Some of what your wife needs is for a clinician to settle, not for you to guess at. Knowing which questions those are, and who answers each, keeps you from deciding her care level over the kitchen table.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The NOT SURE WHICH list and anything medical or supervision-related from your notes.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> These are the items about my wife's care that I don't think I should settle on my own:
>
> [PASTE THE NOT SURE WHICH LIST AND ANYTHING MEDICAL OR SUPERVISION-RELATED]
>
> Turn each one into a question I can ask, and mark who should answer it: her doctor, a nurse, a therapist, a pharmacist, or a care consultant. Group the questions by who answers them so I can ask each person once. Don't answer any of them yourself, and don't suggest changes to her medication or routine. Finish with the three questions you think have to be answered before we look at any setting.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A short set of questions per person, and three you'd put at the top.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Call or message the first person on the list before the end of the week.

PROMPT 4

Make the page you'll read to the social worker

WHY THIS MATTERS

When the social worker calls, you'll want one page, not a folder. This page is what you read from, and what you hand to anyone who wants to help.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've organized about the help my wife needs:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Give me one page with three headings: HELP SHE NEEDS EVERY DAY, MUST HAVE VERSUS WOULD LIKE, and QUESTIONS FOR HER CARE TEAM. Keep each line short enough to read aloud to a social worker. Do not add a recommended setting, a care level, a provider name, or anything about cost. Where I've marked something NOT OBSERVED or NOT SURE, keep that label on the page so no one mistakes it for a confirmed need.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that describes your wife without naming a place for her.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep it. The next step below turns it into something a professional can work from.

Start the setting conversation from her whole picture

The list you have covers what you see at home. The care interview goes through every area of your wife's daily life and records what she needs in each one, so a conversation about settings starts from a complete Family Care Profile instead of a label.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›